

Applying Critical Theory to Gender Equality and violence against women in Türkiye

Gender equality and violence against women are critical issues in Türkiye, deeply rooted in cultural, institutional and ideological structures. For instance, the Turkish civil code and other laws continue to reflect traditional gender roles, which can restrict women's rights in areas such as marriage, divorce, and inheritance. Critical theory, particularly its focus on power dynamics and ideology, provides important insights into understanding the systemic roots and structural causes of gender inequality.

In Türkiye, patriarchy is evident in both formal institutions and everyday cultural practices. For instance, women still hold less than 20% of parliamentary seats.

Unfortunately, this percentage highlights how far we still are from achieving equality in political representation and it reflects societal beliefs that politics is primarily a "male domain".

These belief systems are equally shaped and reinforced by the media which views and portrays women in stereotypical roles such as housemakers or victims. According to Adorno and Horkheimer's theory of the culture industry, these portrayals are intentional and serve to maintain dominant ideologies. In Türkiye, popular TV dramas frequently romanticize submissive female characters, subtly promoting traditional gender roles.

Advancing gender equality in Türkiye requires a transformative approach rooted in Critical Theory, emphasizing emancipation, justice, and universalism to challenge entrenched systems of oppression. There are several ways for transformative change. Firstly, strengthening the implementation of existing laws is one of the most important actions to take in order to prevent violence against women and provide gender equality.

Justice, as framed by critical theory, transcends formal equality to address systemic disparities and ensure fairness in both outcomes and opportunities. For instance, one of the most significant reasons for the increasing rates of violence against women in Türkiye is the lack of deterrent laws and the insufficiency of legal sanctions. The Turkish legal system's leniency toward perpetrators of gender based violence undermines the pursuit of justice. The current government has established a system where even wearing a tie can serve as grounds for sentence reduction. The streets are filled with individuals freely roaming despite having extensive criminal records. It is also important to encourage Türkiye to recommit to international conventions like the Istanbul Convention that facilitate writing a framework to ensure justice through protection of rights and accountability for violations that ensure that women are safe. These agreements highlight the global interrelation of justice issues globally, emphasizing that advancing gender equality in one nation contributes to a universal commitment to justice and the principles of global citizenship.

Secondly, education is very important. Children learn patterns related to gender roles from an early age and these biases shape their behaviours and also self perceptions. Education allows these patterns to be questioned and helps in adopting an egalitarian mindset. It helps address issues like gender-based violence and discrimination by targeting their root causes and teaching children important values such as empathy, respect, and equality, which can play a key role in preventing bullying and discrimination. Moreover, gender equality education allows both boys and girls to feel freer in their career and life choices.

Lastly, changing the cultural norms and attitudes towards gender roles is essential for achieving gender equality. The double burden shows ongoing gender inequalities in society, where women are expected to take care of the domestic chores while simultaneously participating in the workforce. This pressure to balance both work and domestic responsibilities can negatively impact women's mental and physical health. To address this issue, it is necessary to promote a cultural shift in how society views and values traditional gender roles. Promoting the idea that both men and women should share domestic responsibilities is crucial in creating a fairer society.

In conclusion, achieving gender equality and addressing violence against women in Türkiye requires a comprehensive approach that challenges deep rooted societal norms and systems. Strengthening laws and recommitting to international agreements like the Istanbul Convention are critical steps to ensure that women feel protected, and that justice is served. Education plays an equally important role by helping young people question stereotypes, embrace equality, and grow into adults who value fairness and respect. Additionally, changing the attitudes towards traditional gender roles is essential to ease the heavy burden placed on women, allowing both men and women to share responsibilities at home and at work. By taking these steps, Türkiye can build a fairer and more inclusive society. One that not only supports its citizens but also contributes to a global movement for justice and equality.

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